

3,000 YEARS OF MENSWEAR

Since ancient times male clothes have been used as a declaration of social distinction. Every historical age has had its own sartorial codes, either imposed by law or by social pressure – once it was the exact colour of toga that mattered; today it is likely to be the label on a pair of designer jeans that counts. One of the most widespread and enduring items of male clothing is the suit, which from the 19th century onwards gradually evolved from various jacket-and-trousers combinations worn in earlier periods. In the 20th and 21st centuries conventions of male dress have been subverted by youth and sub-cultures, and alternative notions of taste and acceptability for menswear are well established. However, for businesswear and formal occasions, the suit remains the preferred item of male clothing.



c.1187–1064BCE Egyptian priest
in a long-sleeved pleated robe



509BCE–476CE Suit of armour
(reconstructed) with leather cuirass



1690 Restoration justaucorps
(close-fitting coat) worn over waistcoat



1760 Nobleman wearing a silk coat
with matching trousers, and a cravat



18th Century Coat and breeches
(reconstructed) with ornate waistcoat



1832 Shooting outfit of green
morning coat and fitted black trousers



1854 Frock coat and trousers
worn with a blue embroidered waistcoat



1940s Tan jacket and grey
trousers worn over knitted sweater



1954 Teddy boy wearing long jacket
with drainpipe trousers and a string tie



1963 Double-breasted suit by
Pierre Cardin, worn with fedora hat



1968 Mr Fish suit of striped corduroy,
worn with a black polo neck sweater



1973 Belted jacket with pointed
collar and zip pockets, worn unfastened